

ARLINGTON COUNTY
VIRGINIA:
A HISTORY

C. B. Rose, Jr.

ARLINGTON HISTORICAL SOCIETY

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In 1920, the General Assembly adopted an Act changing the name of the County from Alexandria to Arlington.¹ So long as the County seat had remained in the City of Alexandria it had not mattered greatly that the City and County bore the same name. With the shift of the Court House out of the City in 1898 and the increasing vitality and prominence of the County, confusion was bound to result in the minds of outsiders. This finally prompted the legislative action—an action which reportedly took most County residents by surprise. As explained earlier, the choice of name was inspired by a desire to honor Gen. Robert E. Lee whose home had been Arlington House for so long.

The Court decision was rendered in 1922 in the case of *Bennett vs Garrett*. Clarendon was the most populous village of the many developments within Arlington and the residents believed that they would benefit by incorporating as a town. Accordingly, they applied to the Court for a charter in 1920. The case was eventually decided by the Supreme Court of Appeals of Virginia which held that Arlington County was a "continuous, contiguous, and homogeneous community" that could not be subdivided for the purposes of incorporating a portion of it.

After the U. S. Census of 1920, the General Assembly re-districted the State for the purposes of representation in the legislative body. Beginning in 1924, for the first time Arlington had its own Delegate in the House. Previously it had shared this representation with one or more jurisdictions. The first truly Arlington Delegate was Charles T. Jesse. It was not until 1944 that Arlington achieved the status of its own Senator. At that time, too, it was allotted a second Delegate of its own. Arlington had grown.

IMPROVING COMMUNITY SERVICES AND FACILITIES

For some decades the pattern of living in Arlington had been shifting from scattered farmsteads to village-like clusters and subdivisions. The merging of these separate units into a unified whole accelerated after World War I. This transformation manifested itself in a number of ways; each, in turn, strengthened the tendency.

A County-wide Water System

The growing population emphasized the need for a water system to serve the whole community. In 1926, the Board of Supervisors employed an engineer, Asa E. Phillips, to study the situation and devise a plan. A basic question was, "What source of supply?" The

¹ *Acts of Assembly 1920*, Ch. 241.

such a form of government in Virginia, and both Manager and Board had to feel their way. One change was made immediately. Heretofore, the County Clerk-Clerk of Courts had been the Clerk for the governing body. The Arlington Board secured an opinion that it had the right to choose its own Clerk, and appointed Mr. Braden to this position. The County Manager continued to wear two hats until 1947 when the then Manager decided this placed him in the anomolous position of giving orders as the Clerk to himself as Manager and requested the Board to make a change.

From its beginning in 1932 until the end of 1975, Arlington has had just four Managers: Roy S. Braden, 1932-36; Frank C. Hanrahan, 1936-47; A. T. Lundberg, 1947-62; and Bert W. Johnson, 1962-75.

The County Board was now relieved of executive duties and could devote its entire attention to policy-making. The Manager performed all executive and administrative functions except those that were (and are) the prerogative of the Constitutional officers and the School Division. Gradually the new government took shape with a Health Department, Water Department, Highway Department, and an office for auditing and budget preparation under the County Manager.

A major change was made in 1940 when the Sheriff recommended and the Circuit Court approved a move to place the County police force, theretofore under the Sheriff, under the County Manager. Police officers were still appointed as "special officers" by the Court for one year terms. The power to appoint police officers, and for indefinite rather than one year terms, was given to the County Manager by an Act of the General Assembly in 1948.¹⁶

As new demands were placed upon it, the County Government structure was enlarged and became more complex.¹⁷ Even in 1932, however, concentration of responsibility in a single head meant more efficient government. Moreover, the fact that the Magisterial Districts had been abolished and the County Board elected at large, meant a governing body more responsive to the needs of the whole County rather than pitting one section against another. The "Continuous, contiguous, and homogeneous" nature of Arlington had now found expression in its form of government.

THE NEW ARLINGTON

Arlington County's population, which had increased 40% in the decade between 1920 and 1930, despite the loss of territory to Alexan-

¹⁶ *Acts of Assembly*, 1948, Ch. 460.

¹⁷ cf. Office of the County Manager, *Handbook on County Government Organization*, first published Arlington, 1952; Seventh Edition, 1969. For historical background of Departments, etc., cf. Sixth Edition (1964).